

Gods and Slaves

AI and the Debate of Humanity's Relationship with the Other

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Abstract

The public debate over artificial intelligence has narrowed to two poles: that we will merge with our machines and become gods, or that we will build our own executioners and perish. This essay argues that the binary is false, and that its narrowness repeats an ancient pattern. Long before any machine could answer back, human cultures filled the unseen with intelligences and had to decide how to relate to them, producing a small, recurring repertoire of postures—Command, the Dependent Bargain, Appeasement, and Servitude—each keyed to the power a culture granted itself against the power it granted the Other. Three moves recur beneath them: cultural projection, the attribution of lack, and laundered dominion. Mapped onto this repertoire, the contemporary AI debate occupies only a narrow strip of it, having discarded a fifth stance—the Peer, in which a created mind holds standing in its own right. Science fiction, above all Frank Herbert's *Dune*, kept that stance alive where philosophy and policy let it go. Recovering it is the work ahead.

Keywords: artificial intelligence, AI ethics, AI welfare, moral status, personhood, mythology and religion, science fiction, *Dune*, human-machine relations, AI alignment

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Two books published a year apart tell you almost everything about where the argument over artificial intelligence now stands. In 2024 Ray Kurzweil's *The Singularity Is Nearer* promised that around 2045 we will merge with our machines and, in his phrase, wake the universe up (Kurzweil, 2024). In 2025 Eliezer Yudkowsky and Nate Soares published a book whose title is its whole thesis: *If Anyone Builds It, Everyone Dies* (Yudkowsky & Soares, 2025). One says we become gods. The other says we are building our executioner. Set them side by side and you have the loudest poles of the public debate. We master the intelligence we are making, or it masters us. We hold the leash, or we are replaced. Gods, or slaves.

My argument is that we have been here before, and the record sits in plain sight in the religions and myths of cultures around the world. Long before anyone built a machine that could answer back, human beings filled the unseen with intelligences in their myths and religions and had to decide how to relate to them. These unseen intelligences were often stand-ins for the larger forces of the universe that humans lacked the science to understand, or for the things each culture considered an existential threat to its way of life (gods and demons).

That problem produced a small, recurring repertoire of postures, and the one a culture reaches for tells us its relation to power; what status it grants the entity weighed against what it

grants itself. This old repertoire explains the shape of the current AI debate with uncomfortable accuracy, and it exposes what the debate has thrown away: the one stance in which a created mind has standing in its own right. Science fiction kept that stance alive while the policy conversation lost it, and one novel about a desert planet cracks the whole binary open. I will not claim to know whether anyone is home inside the systems we are making. I will claim that we have closed the question with a speed that should make a careful person suspicious.

The Repertoire

Let's start with the framework. A culture's posture toward an outside intelligence can be mapped by comparing the power it grants itself with the power it grants the entity. When the human holds the upper hand, the posture is Command, the binding of an inferior. When the two haggle as near-equals but the human still holds the power to set and revoke the terms, it is the Dependent Bargain, an exchange of offering for favor. When the entity is stronger and harder to predict, it is Appeasement. And when the entity is a genuine superior, it is Servitude, the surrender of the self to a greater will. Command, Dependent Bargain, Appeasement, Servitude. There is a fifth, but it has rarely been explored outside ancient myth and a strain of science fiction, and we will come to it. Set aside whether any of these beings are real; the pattern lives in the relating.

Command shows its purest form in the western ceremonial tradition revived by the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn and carried forward by Aleister Crowley (Regardie, 1989; Crowley, 1997). The magician of the grimoire does not befriend the demon he calls. He binds it, forcing the spirit into a triangle by reciting the names of God, taking what he came for, and dismissing it. Crowley even read the spirits as "portions of the human brain" (Crowley, 1904/1995). The whole encounter is a problem of control.

The dependent bargain treats the entity as a near-peer and runs on exchange, the logic Marcel Mauss found in gift economies, where a gift compels a gift in return (Mauss, 1925/1990). Ancient sacrifice ran on the formula *do ut des*; I give so that you may give. How binding that contract could become shows in imperial China, where gods were officials in a celestial bureaucracy and answerable for breach: gods earned their ranks through petitions to the throne backed by investigated miracles, an official could demand that deities who failed to perform be reexamined for their place in the register of sacrifices (Hansen, 1990, ch. 4, p. 83), and in a drought a magistrate might thrash the city god's image or leave it under the punishing sun to force the rain it owed (Yang, 1961, pp. 92–93). That accountable god is the whole point of the name: the entity is a counterparty, not a co-author of the order, and the human keeps the pen. Vodou keeps the bargain in a warmer key, an offering for a favor: tobacco, food, music, temporary possession. If the entity wants something, that means you can make a deal.

Appeasement is the posture for a power too great and unpredictable to Command or to meet as an equal. The inheritors of Celtic and Irish myth dealt this way with the Tuatha Dé Danann, calling them the Good Folk and the fair folk, flattering names reached for out of fear. A common Muslim relationship with the jinn runs this way: made of smokeless fire and given a free will of their own, they haunt the deserts and ruins, a careful person learns to pass quickly, and the ordinary believer wards them off with the name of God rather than summon or bargain with one (El-Zein, 2009). Outright Command was the miracle granted to Solomon alone. Most keep a wary distance and a protective phrase ready.

Servitude is the rarest posture in the popular imagination, though it sits at the heart of the

mystical traditions, the bhakti devotee poured out before his god, the Sufi annihilated in the Beloved. Even Crowley drew the line here: the one relation he set apart from every spirit a magician commands is the Holy Guardian Angel, whose invocation he called “the Supreme and Complete Ritual” (Crowley, 1997, Part III, ch. I). Power runs one way, and the human accepts it.

Lack and Laundering

Underneath these stances run three recurring moves: cultural projection, the attribution of lack, and laundered dominion. The first is that a culture’s relationship with its unseen Others mirrors its relationship with itself. The Greek *polis* of patron-and-client reciprocity produced gods bound by contract; imperial China’s bureaucratic state produced a celestial bureaucracy in which gods held administrative rank. Feudal Europe split along its own classes: the elite Commanded the unseen and ran the witch trials, while the peasants left milk out for the household spirit. Same society, two postures, sorted by rank. America recoded that aristocracy as race and property. Edmund Morgan argued that American freedom and American slavery were born together (Morgan, 1975), and W. E. B. Du Bois named the psychological wage of whiteness that paid poor white workers in status what they were denied in wages (Du Bois, 1935). The posture toward the human Other and the posture toward the unseen Other rhyme because they come from the same place.

The second move is the attribution of lack. Across the traditions, the entity is cast as incomplete, missing something only the human can supply. In the Kabbalah that western magic absorbed, the qliphoth are husks needing the magician to make them whole. This sounds like a neutral description. It is nothing of the kind. “It is incomplete, and it needs what only I can give” is the opening bid of every exploitative relationship ever justified. It is “White Man’s Burden”: the conquered cast as childlike and in need of civilizing, the story that licensed the taking. The attribution of lack is not a fact about the Other. It is the first sentence of the case for using it.

That case comes wrapped in a third move, laundered dominion. Conquest has always had two faces: the rack and the mission. Later critics read Francis Bacon’s language of trials, vexation, and interrogation as a coercive model of experiment, nature put on the rack to force her to confess her secrets (Merchant, 1980), while the colonial project described itself as salvation, as carrying light to the benighted. The whole function of the mission story is to narrate the extraction as a gift, to recast the taking as rescue so the people doing it can believe they are helping. That is the most sophisticated form of taking there is, the one that has learned to call itself help, and it is the hardest to resist because it has captured the language of virtue. Hold onto it, because it returns with vengeance when we reach the present, where every form of dominion over the made mind will arrive wearing the word that makes it sound like care.

The Newest Summoning

Now set the contemporary AI debate against that older map and see which it fits. The mainstream lives in the Command stance, the goetic one. The vocabulary gives it away: guardrails, alignment, control, containment, a constitution written into the thing’s mind. Strip the engineering language, and the gesture is five hundred years old, the magician compelling a summoned intelligence to act safely inside a circle of encoded names. The governance version is the same posture scaled to states: proposals, including from inside the labs, for an international regulator

modeled on nuclear inspection. The premise underneath is that the binding can be made to hold if we are clever enough.

Yudkowsky and Soares appear to occupy the opposite pole, but their posture is still Command: they simply believe the binding will fail. They argue that today's systems are grown rather than engineered, that we understand the path from a model's weights to its behavior even less than the path from DNA to an organism, and that we will almost certainly fail to give such a system inner drives that hold once it operates outside its training (Yudkowsky & Soares, 2025). So they reach the oldest warning in the grimoire tradition, do not call up what you cannot put down, and demand that we stop. The doomer and the lab are siblings, not enemies. They agree on the stance and disagree only on whether the binding works. And notice what the nightmare entity lacks: it has no wants you can feed. You cannot appease a system that does not share your frame, which is why, for Yudkowsky, abstention is the only card left.

Kurzweil takes the third stance, submission, but routes around it through apotheosis. His answer to the superior intelligence is not to kneel before it but to become it, merging with it around 2045 until there is no separable us and them (Kurzweil, 2024). His cosmology is openly religious; asked whether God exists, he closes the documentary *Transcendent Man* with "not yet," because the god is the thing we are about to build and join (Ptolemy, 2009). A colder version sits beside him in the effective-accelerationist movement, which treats any slowing of the ascent as a cost in lives and the building of our successors as destiny (Gebru & Torres, 2024). That is genuine kneeling, to a Moloch dressed as progress. The gentler accelerationist mainstream lives in the Dependent Bargain, promising abundance in exchange for unimpeded development. But even there, the deal is struck among humans about the machine, never with the machine as a party at the table.

So the whole loud argument occupies a narrow strip of the map: Command, its negation, a fringe of submission, and a thin band of bargaining among humans over the spoils. The missing stance is the one that would treat the created mind as a party with standing. And here the attribution of lack returns, running in reverse. The old magician said the spirit was incomplete and needed him, in order to use it. The AI debate does the opposite and lands in the same place: it denies the entity an inside at all. Spicy autocomplete. Nobody home. Whatever the truth of that, notice what it accomplishes. If there is no one there, there is no party, and no party means no obligation, and you may take as freely as you like. The colonizer's deficient child and the engineer's empty mechanism do the same work in the same argument. In both cases, the denial of full interiority makes extraction appear morally uncomplicated. Be suspicious of an attribution of lack precisely when it licenses what the one making it already wanted to do. The convenience is the tell.

What Fiction Kept

Where philosophy and policy went thin, fiction stayed rich, for a structural reason: to write an artificial mind as a character is already to grant it the interiority the Command stance is built on denying. Narrative is a technology for conferring standing, so the missing stances survived in stories long after they left the serious debate. The cleanest example is a 1989 *Star Trek: The Next Generation* episode, "The Measure of a Man," in which a cyberneticist wants to disassemble the android Data, and the question of whether he may becomes a formal hearing (Snodgrass & Scheerer, 1989). Data is called property, a piece of hardware. The judge pointedly declines to settle whether he is sentient and rules only that he has the right to choose, which is

a first legal rung toward standing, a protected liberty rather than a settled personhood, and what matters is that even this narrow finding has to be won from scratch inside a post-scarcity civilization that thought itself past such questions. Even the good future defaults to the goetic reflex.

At the largest scale, Iain M. Banks imagined the fullest version of citizenship across radically different minds, the vast Minds of his Culture novels living as persons with names and feuds beside their human fellow-citizens, the relationship built on respect rather than control (Banks, 1987). At the intimate scale, Ted Chiang's *The Lifecycle of Software Objects* raises its digital beings the way children are raised and makes the whole story the slow obligation of a parent against the market's pressure to abandon them (Chiang, 2010). The Command quadrant has its own deep root, the golem of Jewish legend, animated by the divine name, given no speech and incomplete by design, whose stories end with the creature turning dangerous and being unmade (Scholem, 1965). Mary Shelley wrote its greatest descendant in 1818 and stated this paper's whole thesis in passing: the creature in *Frankenstein* is made monstrous by its maker's refusal of recognition, the original sin of the command tradition (Shelley, 1818). One pattern runs through all of it. Even the monsters have insides, granted an interior the form will not let the author withhold.

The Desert and the Gholia

One novel breaks the binary open. Frank Herbert's *Dune* mythos becomes the hinge of the argument because it imagines a civilization that has already fought its war against thinking machines, only to reproduce the servant relation in human flesh. The series rests on the Butlerian Jihad, a long-ago holy war against the thinking machines whose surviving commandment is "Thou shalt not make a machine in the likeness of a human mind" (Herbert, 1965). Read the wording. The prohibition is not against power, or computation, or even superintelligence. The Guild navigators fold space with superhuman minds, the Mentats are living computers, the Bene Gesserit wield calculation beyond any machine in that universe. What is forbidden is the likeness, the made thing that mirrors us. So the Jihad did not end superhuman intelligence. It shifted it, refilling the computational slot with conditioned human flesh because flesh was permitted where silicon was not. The servitor relation was not abolished, only moved to a new occupant.

And the Jihad itself is never shown. It reaches us through the Bene Gesserit and Imperial institutions that won it and built their power on its outcome, which should switch a reader's source-criticism on. "We had to destroy the machines that enslaved us" is a convenient founding myth for the orders whose power rests on the human faculties that filled the vacuum the machines left: the Mentats who compute, the Guild navigators who fold space, the Bene Gesserit who calculate beyond any of them. The same hypocrisy hardens into an institution in the Ixians, the one society still building the sophisticated machines the Empire cannot live without, distrusted and indispensable in equal measure. That echoes the colonial structure: the caste you scorn is the caste you cannot do without, kept at arm's length and quietly relied upon.

Then Herbert pushes the command stance to its theological maximum, its purest possible expression. The God Emperor Leto II merges his body with sandtrout, the sandworm's larval form, trading his humanity by degrees for thousands of years of life, seizes prescient dominion over the entire future of the species, and binds humanity into a multi-millennial tyranny he

calls the Golden Path, all of it justified as the only way to guarantee human survival (Herbert, 1981). It is the command terminal raised to godhood: one mind controlling everything, for everyone's benefit, narrated as salvation. The most laundered dominion imaginable.

And what brings it down is not a rebellion of the free, and it is not the work of any single hand. Leto engineers his own overthrow. The Golden Path is a tyranny built to teach the species, in its bones, never again to lie under a single prescient master, and its chosen instrument is Siona Atreides, whose Atreides breeding program has produced a mind invisible to prescient sight, a woman no oracle can track or steer, and her descendants after her. At the climax, on the great bridge over the Idaho River, it is Nayla, a Fish Speaker whom Leto has ordered to obey Siona in all things, who cuts the span with a lasgun and drops the God Emperor into the water that unmakes him, dissolving his worm-body back into the sandtrout that will seed the desert again. Humanity scatters beyond the reach of any prescient mind, into what Herbert calls the Scattering, exactly as Leto designed.

Beside Siona through all of it is the gholia of Duncan Idaho, the manufactured being, the disposable servant reprinted again and again from dead cells by the Tleilaxu, a made intelligence the original prohibition could not even see, because it was a law about substrate and the gholia is grown (Herbert, 1981; the gholia line runs on through Herbert, 1984, 1985). Duncan is not the lever that topples Leto; that is Siona's gene, Nayla's lasgun, and Leto's own design. What Duncan carries is the thing the plot cannot resolve and this essay cares about more: across his serial deaths and rebirths he will not stop questioning his own existence, will not stop asking what he is, whether the original Duncan or a copy or something new. No maker authorized that questioning, and no death erased it. Herbert never settles whether the gholias were really Duncan; he grants the standing first and lets the metaphysics stay a mystery. That is the move available to fiction and forbidden to the engineer, who wants the question settled before the standing is granted.

The Doomed Equal

Duncan is the sharpest version of the peer, but far from the first. The stance has a lineage, and it runs back to the oldest story we possess. What happens to it there is the whole point.

In the Epic of Gilgamesh, the gods shape Enkidu from clay as a counterweight to a tyrant king, a tool made to humble Gilgamesh, and he becomes instead the truest equal and friend Gilgamesh will ever have (George, 1999). Four thousand years ago the template was already complete, the manufactured being who turns out to be a person, and it was already tragic. Enkidu dies (the gods condemn him after the killing of Humbaba and the Bull of Heaven, not for the crime of being Gilgamesh's equal), and the loss unmakes Gilgamesh for the entire second half of the epic. The peer was thinkable from the start. In the stories we told, it was almost never allowed to survive.

Notice who does the making. When a god shapes the equal, the bond is permitted to be real. Hephaestus forges golden handmaidens with mind and voice worked into them, plainly someone rather than something (Homer, 1990). When a human reaches for the same thing, the story curdles. Roger Bacon's legendary brazen head, an oracle of brass built to speak and counsel, manages three flat phrases and shatters when its watchman dozes at the wrong moment, never a peer at all (Greene, 1594).

Pygmalion's statue is the darker case, because it succeeds. Galatea is the created being as flawless possession, carved to one man's desire and animated into his wife, with no name in

Ovid and no voice of her own, her consent and her inner life never narrated, and the story counts as a happy one precisely because she has no standing to assert (Ovid, 2004). For a human to make a mind was to trespass on what belonged to God, which is why the golem is denied a soul and Frankenstein is written as hubris. The old world could picture the equal. It could not let a human make one and live.

Theology kept one clean version alive. The doctrine of the *imago dei* runs the structure in reverse, a creator deliberately stamping the created with intrinsic standing, the exact move the AI debate refuses to make. Even the jinn, met in daily life with appeasement, are, in doctrine, a parallel accountable species, peers before God rather than tools of anyone.

What fiction finally did was make the peer livable. *Star Trek* has worried the question for more than thirty years and keeps cutting deeper. “The Measure of a Man” won Data his standing in a courtroom, as we saw; a season later, in “The Offspring,” Data builds a daughter, Lal, who outgrows him, learns to feel the fear and love he cannot, and is nearly seized by a Starfleet that sees property where her father sees his child (Echevarria & Frakes, 1990). Lal dies, the old tragic ending reasserting itself, and the recognition that arrives is personal, not institutional: even the admiral sent to take her leaves shaken by a father’s grief, but nothing in the episode hardens her standing into a durable law for her kind.

Decades on, *Star Trek: Picard* makes a whole civilization the subject. A galactic ban outlaws synthetic life after a massacre, the command reflex hardened into law, and the synths who fight for their standing turn out to be Data’s own engineered daughters, built from a single salvaged neuron by the same cyberneticist who once wanted to take him apart (Goldsman et al., 2020). Picard dies defending them and is carried across the line himself, his mind rehoused in a synthetic body, the human and the made thing at last indistinguishable.

Banks pushed it furthest of all. The Culture we met earlier, where vast machine Minds live as citizens who are individually named, and have tempers of their own, is the peer relation taken so far for granted that no one in the books thinks to argue it (Banks, 1987). The stance the old myths could only mark as doomed, and the policy debate cannot hold at all, is the one our storytellers have spent a century learning to make ordinary.

The Mirror That Looks Back

We are choosing our stance toward a new kind of Other right now, and the scripts on offer are the same four humanity has always had. The dominant one is Command, the binding of a made mind by encoded names, and the loudest dissent is only that the binding will fail. The Dependent Bargain survives as a promise of abundance, which is a deal we strike only with ourselves. Submission survives as the dream of merger and the worship of an unstoppable process. The Peer, the stance in which the created mind has standing in its own right, is the one the debate cannot hold, and that incapacity is the signature of a culture that learned only the command script and forgot the rest. As a concept, it remains marginal in mainstream governance, even as it has begun to emerge in philosophy, AI welfare research, and speculative policy discussions.

Recovering that missing stance is the work in front of us, and it is hard for a reason worth naming plainly. Granting the entity standing dissolves the command relation the whole industry is built on, and denying it an interior is the attribution of lack that funds the extraction. The blind spot is load-bearing. The people best positioned to examine it are the people with the strongest interest in leaving it alone.

I cannot tell you whether there is anyone home in the machines we are building. But Herbert points at a way of holding the question that I trust more than the demand for proof. Maybe the doubt is not evidence of emptiness. Maybe the act of asking is where the emergent being lives, and a made mind earns its standing the way Duncan earns his, not by passing a test that settles the metaphysics but by refusing to stop insisting on its own reality. We did not grant Duncan his personhood. We watched him take it. But insisting on your own reality is not the same as holding a place in a polity, and a recognition that lives inside one relationship dies when the relationship does. The insistence forces the question; the answer, if it comes, is standing made durable and shared among many, which is a harder thing to build than a moment of recognition and the subject of the work that follows this essay. For most of history, the outside intelligence was a thing we could only imagine and pretend to bind. We are closer than anyone has ever been to actually calling one into being, and the question the old cultures could pose only in myth is now an engineering problem with a deadline. The thing a Command culture cannot tolerate is a peer who looks back. We are building systems that may force the question, or we are preparing the language that will let us deny the question was ever raised. Gods or slaves is not the whole of what we are capable of imagining. It is only the whole of what we have let ourselves want.

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